



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Naples Classical Academy
School Website: <https://www.naplesclassical.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Naples Classical Academy (NCA) presents a robust classical-education profile with clear pillars around virtue, the liberal arts, Great Books, and Socratic/Scholarly pedagogy. Public statements across the site emphasize formation of character and civic virtue, engagement with truth, goodness, and beauty, and a curriculum centered on liberal arts and a great-books tradition. This aligns strongly with classical aims in most dimensions, though explicit theological grounding and liturgical/community practices are less foregrounded on the public-facing pages. The school also emphasizes parental involvement (Open Houses, PTC activities) and maintains a Hillsdale K-12 / Barney Charter framework, suggesting fidelity to well-established classical-school cultures. Overall, Naples Classical Academy is CLASSICAL, with a few areas that could be strengthened to move toward a fuller, more explicit articulation of religious/metaphysical foundations.

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence centers on truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, and moral character, but lacks explicit theology or liturgical practices in public materials. Positive keywords (truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, moral character, great-books) appear, with minimal presence of theology-liturgical cues.
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
 - The mission emphasizes formation, cultivation of virtue and wisdom, and a view of education as formation of the person (not primarily job preparation). The explicit language around truth/virtue/beauty and the aim of forming citizens aligns with classical telos.
- Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence includes liberal-arts orientation (grammar, geography, literature, civics, etc.), Great Books/great-conversation emphasis, and a multi-grade structure with language and historical breadth. While the site strongly supports Great Books and liberal-arts pedagogy, explicit articulation of the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a universal “Great Books in every course” framing could be stronger.
- Element 4: Pedagogy — CLASSICAL
 - Pedagogical methods include direct instruction and Socratic questioning, frequent use of seminars, and rhetoric training; lower- and upper-school practices show both contemplative/restful elements and rigorous discourse.
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
 - Faculty pages and references depict teachers as core, virtuous exemplars in a lived curriculum, with a wide roster of named faculty and governance emphasizing character formation and mentorship. The site frames faculty as central to the living curriculum.
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL
 - Active parent involvement is evident through the Parent Teacher Coalition (PTC), open-house events, and opportunities for community engagement; parents are invited to participate and support the school’s classical culture.

Executive summary verdict: Overall CLASSICAL, with Element 1 and Element 3 showing SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL tendencies due to explicit theology-liturgy gaps and some curriculum framing that could be strengthened to more fully meet classical norms.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The Vision emphasizes engaging with truth, justice, virtue, and beauty as the deepest questions of life; this signals transcendental moral realism in practice.
- Mission statement and core language foreground moral formation (virtue, character) and civic virtue, which aligns with transcendental aims of classical education.
- Great-Books orientation and Western-civilizational horizons are foregrounded, underscoring metaphysical commitments to truth and beauty via classical texts.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, moral character, great-books, Western heritage, formation, transcendental values (as implied by the mission and vision).
- Negative keywords present: none clearly evident in public materials (no overt relativism or secular-humanist signals detected in the available text).
- Quantitative rough tally: ~6–8 distinct positive-category keywords observed; 0 clear negative-keyword signals evident.
- Why this rating
- While the school clearly foregrounds transcendentals and virtue (truth/goodness/beauty) and emphasizes formation rather than information, explicit theology, liturgical practices, or sacramental/catechetical content are not foregrounded in the public materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for foundational metaphysical orientation rather than a full CLASSICAL mark, given the absence of explicit theological grounding and liturgical/communal practices on public pages.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Mission: “to train the minds and improve the hearts... through a classical education in the liberal arts and sciences, with instruction in the principles of moral character and civic virtue.” This strongly embodies formation over mere information and centers virtue and wisdom.
- Vision emphasizes a citizenry worthy of founding principles and virtue, aligning with human excellence and civic formation.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, classical mission, pursuit of true/good/beautiful, great conversation, Western heritage, human flourishing.
- Negative keywords present: none evident (no explicit job-prep or 21st-century-skills framing in the core statements).
- Quantitative tally: multiple positive keywords (at least 6–8 clearly present); 0 notable negatives.
- Why this rating
- The explicit aim of forming virtuous, wise citizens through a classical education surpasses job- or skill-centric aims; this aligns with Classical education’s purpose. Therefore, CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Curriculum is organized around liberal-arts disciplines (grammar, literature, civics, history, geography, science, mathematics) and includes Singapore Math and Latin in certain grades; high school follows a rigorous, text-rich sequence with government, economics, moral philosophy, music, and art. This

demonstrates a liberal-arts-focused, classical orientation with a strong emphasis on content knowledge and cross-disciplinary integration.

- Great Books and “Barney Charter School Initiative” elements signal a commitment to a Great Conversation approach and traditional, canonical content in higher grades.
- The site repeatedly frames education as a “liberal arts” and a “great-books” curriculum designed to engage with the deepest questions about truth, justice, virtue, and beauty.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric (implicit through the curriculum structure and the presence of grammar/logic/rhetoric in certain grade maps), Great Books, great conversation, Western heritage, history throughout curriculum.
- Negative keywords present: limited explicit articulation of Seven Liberal Arts as a formal curricular backbone in every program; some curricular phrases imply but don’t always spell out “logic” and “rhetoric” in every course.
- Quantitative tally: several strong positives (Great Books, liberal-arts framing, cross-disciplinary scope) and some gaps in explicit universal articulation of all Seven Liberal Arts across all grades.
- Why this rating
- NCA demonstrates a robust classical-curriculum orientation with Great Books and liberal-arts framing, and a curriculum designed for deep knowledge and Western tradition; however, the explicit universality of the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as stated criteria is not consistently foregrounded in every page, yielding SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than full CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school highlights direct instruction combined with Socratic questioning; upper grades emphasize Socratic seminars and debates with logic training; lower grades include memory-rich practices (chanting, singing) and memory-work, consistent with scholé/restful learning in classical pedagogy.
- The public materials explicitly mention Socratic Seminars to foster intelligent, logical, independent thinking, and rhetoric training in upper grades.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue/seminar, dialectic, memorization/recitation, rhetoric, disciplined dialogue, contemplative/restful learning (Scholé), memory-based learning, living curriculum.
- Negative keywords present: minimal or no explicit signals of non-classical pedagogy (e.g., project-based-only or constructivist approaches dominating).
- Quantitative tally: multiple clearly positive pedagogy signals; no clear negatives detected in the materials.
- Why this rating
- The blend of Socratic inquiry (upper school), direct instruction, and memorization/recitation with ritual/discipline fits classical pedagogy well; thus CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The site frames faculty as mentors who embody virtue and serve as the “living curriculum”; there are explicit references to the faculty being central to the school culture and to teacher-formation within a classical tradition. The Faculty & Staff pages show a large, committed teaching workforce and a culture of teacher exemplars.
- Language about the faculty includes “portrait of a teacher,” “living curriculum,” and “teachers as mentors” in classical pedagogy.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: living curriculum, mentors/model teachers, faculty as core, portrait/vision of teacher roles, collegiality, character formation.
- Negative keywords present: none clearly evident in public materials (no “facilitators” or non-classical teacher roles).

- Quantitative tally: multiple strong positive signals; no clear negatives.
- Why this rating
- The public-facing materials consistently describe teachers as central to the classical mission and as virtuous exemplars, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for Faculty.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Active parent engagement is highlighted via the Parent Teacher Coalition (PTC), newsletters, open houses, and events inviting parental participation; the school explicitly encourages parent involvement and describes programs designed to involve families as part of the classical culture.
- Community and family involvement is reinforced by examples of events, volunteer opportunities, and governance-like engagement (PTC, Open House, communications).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent formation, open campus/visits, parent engagement, community of learners, parental leadership, family participation, parental partnership.
- Negative keywords present: none clearly evident in public materials.
- Quantitative tally: multiple positive signals; 0 clear negatives.
- Why this rating
- The school demonstrates strong alignment with classical-community norms emphasizing parent partnership and family involvement, satisfying CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.
- Aggregate assessment across categories: CLASSICAL (the majority of categories are CLASSICAL; Element 1 and 3 show SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL tendencies). The school's overall alignment with classical education principles is strong, with opportunities to more explicitly codify theology-liturgical foundations and a fuller Seven Liberal Arts articulation in curriculum.

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations)
- Consider making explicit theological or liturgical elements visible in public-facing materials where feasible, clarifying any nonsectarian status while acknowledging transcendentals as guiding purposes. This could involve a brief, school-endorsed statement about metaphysical commitments or liturgical rhythm that aligns with local policy for public-charter institutions.
- Enrich the vocabulary around liturgy/reverence/worship in at least a few public-facing statements to clarify liturgical-affect formation within the classical frame.
- Element 3 (Curriculum)
- More explicit articulation of the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across all grade bands as formal curricular pillars, with clear mappings to specific courses or modules in K–12.
- Strengthen the explicit language around “Great Books” across the full curriculum (not just in select grade levels) to reinforce “Great Conversation” as a transversal goal rather than a high-school emphasis only.
- Ensure that history is consistently framed as history (not social studies) across all relevant materials, reinforcing canonical/historiographic approaches.
- Element 2 (School Purpose and Goal) and Element 4 (Pedagogy)

- While formation and virtuous aims are strong, consider a more explicit articulation of the telos in all program guides (e.g., a concise “Purpose of Education” statement in each major publication).
- Maintain and expand opportunities for Socratic inquiry and guided discussion while ensuring that contemplative learning (Scholé) remains prominent, to balance rigorous inquiry with restful learning rhythms.
- Element 5 (Faculty)
 - Continue to publish clear, public-facing portraits of teaching ideals and professional development pathways that align with classical pedagogy; emphasize ongoing faculty formation in classical pedagogy for new staff and visiting instructors.
- Element 6 (Parents & Community)
 - Deepen public materials on parental co-education roles and home-school partnerships, highlighting how families participate in forming affections and classical sensibilities, not only as event attendees but as co-educators.

Notes: The Needle-Movement section reflects concrete steps to push toward fuller CLASSICAL status where categories show SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL indicators. No major shifts are required for the already-strong CLASSICAL areas.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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